would feed hungry millions? Both sides made strong arguments. A proposal to isolate Vijayapuri by building a high wall around it on the valley floor was floated too, but was deemed impractical. No other site was found feasible for the dam. Not surprisingly, the pro-development team won, led by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru himself, who wrote, 'The idea that this place, where so much of our ancient history and culture lie hidden under the earth, should be lost forever under the new lake has distressed me greatly. Yet the choice had to be made for the sake of the needs of today and tomorrow.'[7] Simultaneously, Nehru also initiated a gigantic effort to excavate, study and document Vijayapuri, and to salvage some of its remains.

Ironically, as the pace of excavations and discoveries picked up during 1954–60, scholars realized that the site was even more significant than they had earlier thought, making its impending submergence all the more painful. But too much had already been put into motion and the decision was irreversible, leading the ASI to characterize it as an 'archaeological tragedy'.

Before Vijayapuri was submerged forever, only nine of its monuments were 'saved' and rebuilt on higher ground, detached from their original urban context.[*] Miniature models of fourteen other sites were made. Fortunately, the city was extensively excavated, mapped out and photographed before submersion, so we can at least imagine what a walk down its streets might have felt like. Let's go on one such city walk, as if we were time travelling to it in late third century CE, observing things based on the knowledge we've gleaned from archaeology and other historical sources.

A Stroll through Vijayapuri

Let's begin our walk inside the citadel from where the Ikshvakus ruled Vijayapuri. Part of this citadel area rests on higher ground overlooking the river. It has a moat and mud-brick rampart walls. Inside is a structure, likely the palace of the Ikshvakus, along with many 'residential buildings, barracks, stables, cisterns, baths, and square wells or soak pits'. We notice two ornamental stepped bathing tanks with underground drainage.[8] The first